Alpha

N-9M Flying Wing

B-2A Spirit

RQ-4 Global Hawk (UAV)

1895 John "Jack" Knudsen Northrop is born.
1927 Northrop forms the Avion Corporation.
1929 Avion becomes part of the United Aircraft and Transport Corporation.
1931 Northrop Aviation Corporation is established by Jack Northrop and Donald Douglas.
1935 Howard Hughes sets a new speed record in a Northrop Gamma.
1937 The Northrop Corporation ceases trading and becomes part of Douglas Aircraft.

1939 Northrop and Moye Stephens set up the Northrop Corporation at Hawthorne, CA.
1942 The tiny Northrop N-9M, an experimental flying wing, flies.
1944 The twin boom P-61 Black Widow night interceptor, the first aircraft to use radar, enters USAAF service.
1947 The jet-powered XB-49 flying wing bomber takes to the sky.
1948 The XP-89 Scorpion interceptor makes its maiden flight.

1950 The US government orders the destruction of all Northrop flying wing bombers.
1955 Northrop develops the N-156 lightweight fighter concept.
1959 The USAF replaces the Lockheed T-33 with the N-156T/T-38 advanced trainer.
1961 The supersonic T-38A Talon enters service with the USAF.
1962 Northrop receives a contract from the US government to build the N-156F for the FX fighter program.

1964 The first F-5As and F-5Bs are supplied under the Military Assistance Program.
1974 The YF-17 loses out to the YF-16 in the USAF's Lightweight Fighter competition.
1981 Jack Northrop dies in February.
1988 In November, the B-2 Spirit "flying wing" is revealed to the public.
1991 The YF-23 is beaten in the USAF's Advanced Tactical Fighter competition.
1994 Northrop acquires Grumman.
1998 Maiden flight of the RQ-4 Global Hawk UAV, developed by Northrop Grumman.

Northrop's jet-powered interceptor, the XP-89 prototype, took to the sky for the first time in August 1948 and, a little over two years later, entered service as the F-89 Scorpion. The company's next venture was a lightweight supersonic fighter, the N-156, which was designed to be cheap to buy and maintain. It was developed in tandem with a new two-seat jet trainer design (N-156T), which had a similar layout and appearance. In 1959, the USAF selected the trainer to replace its Lockheed T-33s and, as the T-38 Talon, it entered service as the world's first supersonic advanced trainer. The fighter version followed it into production as the F-5A and F-5B Freedom Fighters.

The popularity of the F-5 series encouraged Northrop to focus on similar lightweight fighter designs, leading to the development of the YF-17 Cobra. Though unsuccessful in competition with the YF-16 Fighting Falcon, Northrop set about modifying the design, with McDonnell Douglas, for the US Navy's reduced-weight combat jet. The resulting F/A-18 Hornet entered US Navy service in 1983. Northrop's last fighter was another USAF competition entrant, this time for the Advanced Tactical Fighter contract contest. In partnership with McDonnell Douglas, Northrop's YF-23 was pitted against Lockheed, Boeing, and General Dynamics whose design, the YF-22, was the eventual winner. Though the YF-23 incorporated more stealth material and was faster, it lacked agility. Northrop acquired Grumman in 1994 and became Northrop Grumman. The company continues to manufacture aircraft and has extended across other military technology fields.

Having been shown an outline design for the B-2 Spirit in 1980, Jack Northrop died in 1981 without knowing that his flying wing concept would come to fruition within a few short years. Unveiled to the public in 1988, the Northrop B-2 Spirit was designed to generate a minimal radar profile. Still in USAF service with its Global Strike Command, the "Stealth Bomber" represents the ultimate realization of Northrop's vision.

Stealth bomber
The Northrop Grumman B-2 used by the USAF is also known as the "Stealth Bomber." Though developed after the death of Jack Northrop, it is the result of his life's work.